

Kauda Baji: Proposed Rules

For review

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Why this document

I'm currently working on a hobby project to build an AI agent that plays Kauda Baji. The idea is to build a complete model of the game in code, then design AI agents that can play it. In the future, time permitting, there may even be a robot that plays the game with you in real life.

I've progressed though making models for the board, player, pieces, and moves. The next remaining step is defining the rules.

And this is where I need your help!

The ask is for you to please read this document and provide feedback if you agree or disagree with each rule. Because a computer will be playing using these rules, they must be fully unambiguous. Anything marked as a *question for the family* at the end is genuinely open — I want your opinion.

If the rule set is agreed upon by all parties, it will enable my project progress.

I would be grateful for your time and feedback.

Terms used

Our game is played in Gujarati, but code is typically written in English so I've had to come up with some terms for common concepts. Here are the terms I will use in this document, and their meanings and translations.

Piece

Trans.(ફક્કી, ફૂકડી) - One of 6 movable objects belonging to one player.

Tuple

Trans.(દૂગલું, તિગલું, ચૌગલું, ...) - A player's own pieces stacked on the same square and moving together as a unit.

Tuple Size

The number of pieces in a tuple. A દૂગલું has size 2, a ચૌગલું has size 4, etc.

Kaudi

One of six cowrie shells thrown together to generate a move. Plural: *kaudis*.

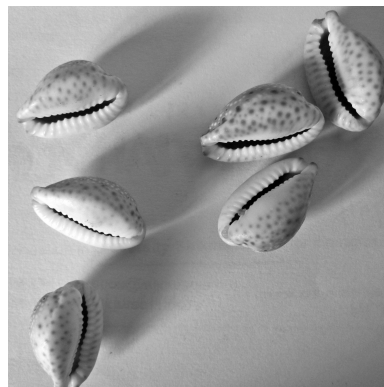
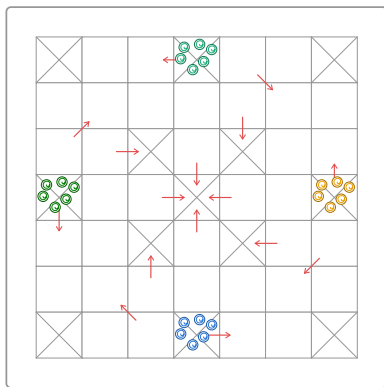
Safe square

A square marked with a corner-to-corner cross. The starting squares and the centre square are safe.

Kill

Removing an opponent's tuple from the board. Killed pieces go back to their owner's starting square and begin their journey again.

The board and pieces



The board is a 7×7 grid of squares. Four players sit at the four edges; each player owns the edge nearest them. Every player's pieces start on the same square: the crossed square in the middle of that player's own edge. This is the player's **starting square**. From there, pieces travel around and inward, and all four players finish on the single square at the very centre of the board.

Twelve squares carry a corner-to-corner cross, and one more sits at the centre — these are the **safe squares**, marked in the diagram above. Every other square is ordinary. What makes safe squares special is covered in the rules below — in short, no piece can ever be killed while it sits on one.

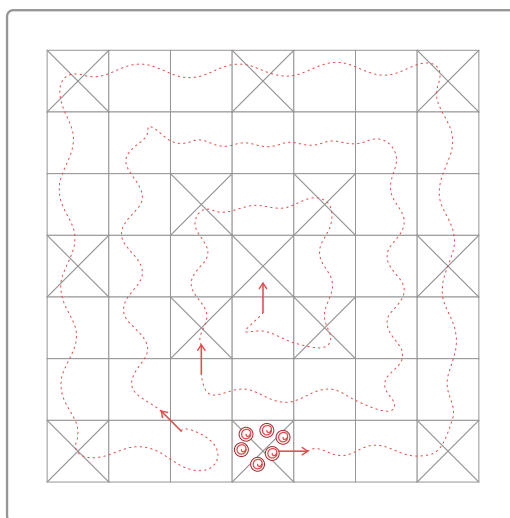
Each player has six pieces of their own colour. A piece stands alone on the board until it lands on a square already holding one of that player's own pieces, at which point the two combine into a tuple and continue the journey together (see *Piece* and *Tuple* in Terms used).

Moves are generated by throwing a set of six *kaudis* — cowrie shells — together. Each kaudi can land one of two ways: mouth-up or mouth-down. How a throw translates into a move is covered in a later rules section.

Moving through the board

Every piece follows the same route from its starting square to the centre. The route is identical for all four players, just rotated to begin at each player's own edge.

A piece begins on its **starting square** — the crossed square in the middle of the player's edge — and travels anticlockwise around the outer ring of the board. At the **first arrow**, it turns inward onto the first inner band and continues **clockwise** around that band. At the **second arrow**, it turns inward again onto the second inner band, still travelling clockwise. The **third and final arrow** then carries the piece onto the centre square, completing its journey.



The rules

Rule 1 — Landing on an opponent: equal or bigger kills

If your tuple lands on a square holding an opponent's tuple, and your tuple is the **same size or bigger**, the opponent's tuple is killed. Your tuple takes the square; their pieces go back to their start.

The same happens if the landing tuple is strictly bigger — a Red 3 landing on a Blue 2 kills it just the same. Equal size is enough; the attacker never needs to outnumber the defender.

Rule 2 — Landing on an opponent: smaller coexists

If your tuple lands on a square holding an opponent's tuple and yours is **strictly smaller**, nothing is killed. Both tuples share the square.

Notice what this means: whenever two opponents share a square, the tuple that was there first is always the bigger one. The smaller tuple is a guest on a stronger tuple's square.

Rule 3 — Leaving a shared square: the bigger tuple kills on exit

When two opponents share a square and the **strictly bigger** tuple moves away, it kills the smaller tuple as it leaves.

The reverse is free: if the *smaller* tuple moves away first, no kill happens — it simply escapes.

So sharing a square is dangerous for the guest. The smaller tuple sits under threat until either it leaves, or the bigger tuple leaves and kills it on the way out.

Rule 4 — Safe squares: no kills, ever

No kill of any kind can happen on a safe square. Any number of tuples, of any sizes, from any players, can share a safe square. Landing there kills nothing, and leaving a shared safe square kills nothing.

Rule 5 — Three or more players on one square: settle each pair separately

When a tuple lands on a square holding tuples from more than one opponent, apply Rules 1 and 2 to **each opponent separately**. The lander kills every opponent tuple that is its size or smaller, and coexists with every opponent tuple that is bigger.

Exit kills work the same way: a departing tuple kills every strictly smaller opponent tuple it leaves behind, and spares the rest.

What follows from these rules

These are not extra rules — they are consequences of Rules 1–5. I list them because they answer situations that caused arguments in the past.

- **Two opponent tuples of equal size can never share an ordinary square.** Landing with equal size kills (Rule 1), so the situation can never arise in the first place.
- **On a shared ordinary square, the resident is always bigger than the guest.** Coexistence only ever begins with a smaller tuple landing on a bigger one (Rule 2).
- **Big tuples are strong but slow to threaten.** A size-3 tuple can only be killed by a size-3 or bigger landing on it — but it also spends three pieces on one square.
- **A lone piece is never safe on an opponent's square.** As a guest it can be killed the moment the resident moves (Rule 3).

Questions for the family

1. **Does a kill earn an extra throw of the kaudis?** Some of us remember playing with this, some without.
2. **Must a player make at least one kill before their pieces may enter the inner rings?** Several Chowka Bhara variants play this way. Do we?
3. **When killed pieces return to the start, do they return as single pieces, or as the tuple they were?** My proposal: as single pieces — the tuple is destroyed, not relocated.

Please mark up anything you disagree with, or reply with the version you remember. Once we agree, this becomes the reference for both the physical board and the computer version I am building.

Kaudi photo: Sodabottle, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons.